FAITH COLLEGES
COLLEGE OF COMPUTING AND INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY
ITELEC1: Integrative Programming and Techniques

ARTWORK ANALYSIS

Balota (2024)

Applying the Art Criticism Process

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Title of Artwork:

Balota (2024)

Director:

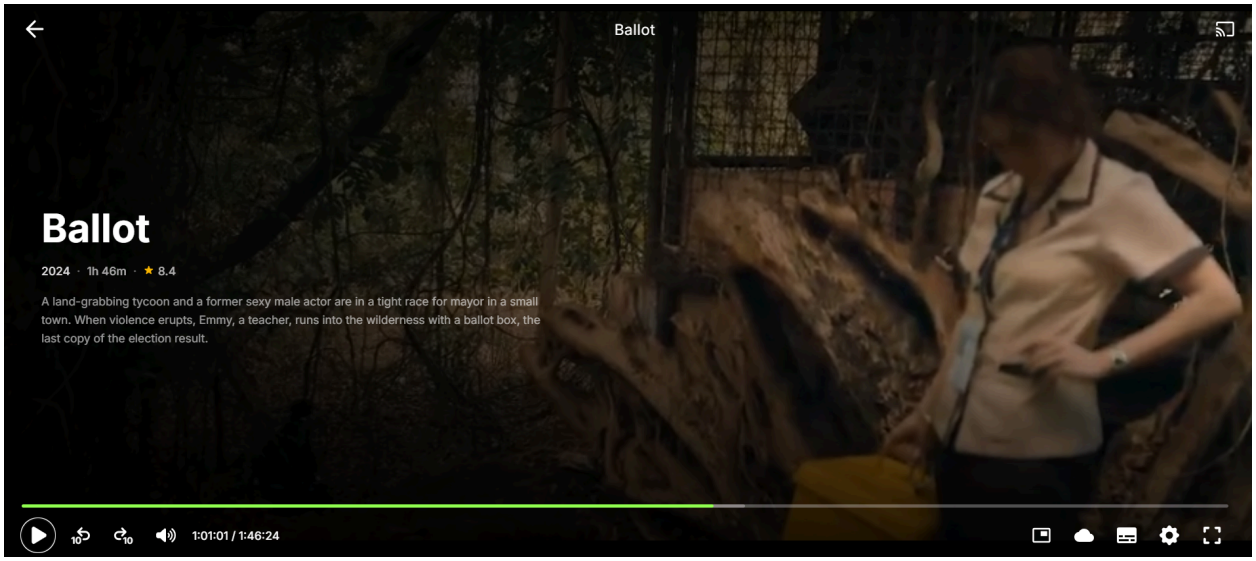
Dakip "Kip" Oebanda

Type of Artwork:

Film

Selected Section:

1:01:01 – 1:06:40



Selected 5-minute Sequence from Balota (2024)

I. Observation

Scene 1 (1:01:01 to 1:03:13)

The scene takes place in a forested, mountainous area during daylight, with green and brown tones visible throughout the setting. Teacher Emmy is shown walking while carrying a yellow ballot box, which is handcuffed to her right wrist. A man wearing a black denim jacket, with a bandage visible on his upper thigh, appears in the background, walking toward her.

He speaks first, saying, "Totoo pala ang chismis, maganda si Ma'am Emmy, sayang." Emmy responds and continues speaking with him. He states that his boss has ordered him to find her, dead or alive. As he steps closer, closing the distance between them, Emmy leans toward him and whispers something that is not audible to the audience. She then attacks him.

He slaps her, and she kicks him. He grabs her by the throat with both hands. She is shown pushing against his arms and moving her body from side to side, the ballot box still handcuffed to her wrist and visible in frame throughout the struggle. She reaches down, picks up a sharp object from the ground, and uses it to stab him in the neck. Blood is visible on his neck and on her hands following this action. She asks him, "Nasaan ang anak ko?" He responds, "Edi hanapin mo." She says, "Tanginamo." She then pushes him, and he falls down the slope and out of frame.

Scene 2 (1:03:13 to 1:06:40)

The scene opens with the camera moving rapidly across surrounding trees and greenery, the image blurred and unsteady, before settling inside a moving car. Two policemen and a young man, later identified as Enzo, Emmy's son, are shown seated together inside the car, with Enzo positioned between them. Banana trees are visible through the windows as the car moves. One policeman holds a cellphone to his ear and says, "Yes boss, oo kasama ko na," followed by, "Ako na bahala dito." The car comes to a stop.

The other policeman says, "Hoy ano yan?" and picks up an object from the floor of the car, shown to be a cellphone. He wipes his hand on Enzo's shirt. The phone rings, and a voice is heard saying, "Anak, naririnig mo ba ako?" The policeman says, "Sabi mo hindi mo nakakausap ang nanay mo?" He grabs Enzo by the neck with one hand and asks him if he knows that lying to a police officer is a crime. He opens the car door and exits the vehicle.

Enzo remains inside and says, "Sir, tulungan niyo naman po ako." The policeman outside opens the car door and tells Enzo to get out. Enzo asks, "Pwede po ba mag-usap muna tayo?" The policeman replies, "Oo, sige, mag-usap tayo," and pulls Enzo out of the car by the arm. Enzo's face is shown wet with tears. Nearby, the second policeman was shown with a slight smile before exiting the vehicle as well.

Enzo is next seen in a grassy, overgrown field. A policeman tells him to kneel, and he lowers himself to his knees. Emmy appears on screen holding the phone to her ear, with visible dirt and marks on her face and clothing. She says, "Nak, nak, sabihin

mo," and does not complete the sentence before the frame returns to Enzo. A policeman tells him to ask his mother where she is. Enzo says, "Ma, nasaan ka ba?" Emmy responds, "Nak, sabihin mo, sabihin mo nasa," and stops speaking, her voice breaking mid sentence. Enzo is shown again as Emmy's voice is heard saying that she will return to the mayor's house.

The policeman says, "Ah okay, sige, magpaalam ka na." A second policeman raises a gun and points it at the back of Enzo's head. Emmy's voice comes through the phone, saying, "Huwag niyo siyang saktan." Enzo says he is going to say his goodbyes. He and Emmy continue speaking to each other over the phone. A gunshot is heard, occurring without any change in the surrounding sound beforehand. Emmy is shown screaming her son's name, her face wet with tears, before she lowers herself to her knees.

II. Analysis

Cinematography

The sequence relies heavily on shifting distance and framing to control the audience's emotional closeness to Emmy. In the first shot, she is close to the camera and the man approaching is clear and small in the background. The audience is positioned directly behind her so that the threat is visible before she reacts to it herself. This discomfort builds further through a shot that shows her own point of view as the man closes in, putting the viewer in the same moment of decision she is experiencing, rather than letting them watch from afar. Once their conversation begins, the camera pulls back into a calm, evenly spaced two shot, a contrast that reflects how convincingly Emmy conceals her fear, since even the framing appears to accept her composure as genuine. A

closer shot on her face shortly after suggests that her true feelings differ from what she expresses aloud, tired and controlled at once.

As the confrontation turns physically violent, the camera pulls back to a distance normally reserved for intimate or personal moments, which makes the scene more disturbing because that level of closeness is usually associated with tenderness, not harm. The fight itself is shot with a shaky, hand-held camera, and the blurring effect of that duplicates the physical chaos of the fight, yet maintains the yellow ballot box in view the whole time, handcuffed to Emmy's wrist and impossible to put down or lose, even accidentally. When she defeats her attacker, it was shown from a high angle, a technique often used to diminish a character, an indication that the balance of power has shifted decisively to her. The camera then remains close on both figures rather than cutting away, denying the audience a clean sense of victory and instead framing the moment as heavy and unresolved. The scene closes on the forest floor before the transition into the next scene, which opens with a rapid, unsteady pan across the surrounding trees, carrying the visual instability of the fight directly into the following segment before the camera settles inside the car where Enzo is shown seated between the two policemen.

This visual language continues into the second half of the sequence. Enzo is framed tightly between the two policemen inside the car, with almost no space around him, so that the composition itself suggests entrapment before any other threat occurs. When the older officer leans into the vehicle, a low angle exaggerates his physical presence, reflecting his authority over Enzo. Once Enzo is pulled outside, the camera remains fixed inside the car, watching through the window and partly obstructed by it, a restricted viewpoint that places the audience in the same helpless position as the driver

left behind. The sequence returns to Emmy in close up, her face bruised as she listens to the call without any corresponding image of what happens to her son, making her expression the sole means through which the audience understands the violence taking place elsewhere.

Editing

The film's editing reinforces the emotional structure established by its cinematography. The transition out of the forest confrontation avoids a clean cut, opening the next scene instead on a rapid pan that carries the disorientation of the fight forward, denying the sequence a moment of visual rest between the two settings. This choice also compresses time: the audience is given no interval to process Emmy's escape before being placed in a new location and a new threat, mirroring how little relief her survival actually offers her within the story.

Once the phone call begins, the editing alternates between Emmy in the forest and the car carrying Enzo, connecting two physically separate locations through a single conversation. This parallel structure allows the audience to understand both sides of the exchange simultaneously, and because the audience is aware of the danger Enzo faces before Emmy is, the tension of the scene is heightened. The pacing of these cuts also shifts as the call progresses: the exchanges grow shorter and more frequent as the scene approaches the gunshot, a tightening rhythm that mirrors the narrowing options available to both mother and son.

When the gunshot finally comes, the film does not cut directly to the act itself, but stays on Emmy's reaction. The choice to do away with the drama of the killing itself and

to hold onto the feelings of the moment. Her reaction produces a scene that is less dramatic than restrained. The editing throughout the sequence consistently favors silence and compression over visuals, a pattern that reflects the film's broader argument that violence within this system operates efficiently and without any need for dramatic emphasis.

Sound Design

The confrontation in the forest mainly uses sounds that come from the scene itself, such as breathing, physical impacts, and the sounds of the struggle, without background music to make the violence more dramatic. The telephone functions as a sound bridge between the forest and the car, connecting the two locations before the editing does so visually, and reinforcing that Emmy's fate and her son's fate remain tied together despite the physical distance between them. Throughout the exchange with Enzo, the policeman's tone remains calm and conversational even as he issues a threat, particularly in the instruction for Enzo to say his goodbyes, and this contrast between a composed vocal delivery and the intensity of the threat suggests that such violence has become an unremarkable part of the system depicted in the film. The gunshot itself occurs abruptly, without the buildup or emphasis common in depictions of violence, and this direct sound choice increases the shock of the moment while reflecting how easily such violence occurs within the story's world.

Mise en Scène

The visual composition of the settings, costumes, and objects within the frame further supports the sequence's themes. Both the forest and the grassy field where Enzo is taken are isolated locations removed from public view, reflecting the vulnerability of both characters, since neither is in a place where help could realistically arrive. The bandage visible on the attacker's thigh suggests that violence is already a routine part of his role, while Emmy's disheveled appearance by the end of the fight visually communicates the physical toll of her resistance. Amid the greens and browns of the forest, the yellow ballot box remains visually distinct throughout the chaos of the struggle, and the handcuff binding it to Emmy's wrist ensures that this contrast in color, and the object itself, cannot leave the frame at any point during the fight.

III. Contextualization

Balota (Oebanda, 2024) premiered at the 2024 Cinemalaya Independent Film Festival and addresses the ongoing issue of election related violence in the Philippines. This subject reflects a documented reality, as public school teachers are required by law to serve as members of the Board of Election Inspectors during national elections. Their responsibilities include guarding and transporting ballot boxes, often in remote areas influenced by powerful political families and their private armed groups.

This danger is not merely fictional. In the May 1995 elections, teacher Filomena Tatlonghari of Mabini, Batangas was shot and killed by armed men while she held tightly onto a ballot box during an attempted ballot snatching, having just finished the vote count with her fellow election inspectors (ABS-CBN News, 2025). Decades later, similar

incidents have continued to occur, including the burning of a polling precinct in Taysan, Batangas in 2007, which resulted in the death of a teacher serving on the Board of Election Inspectors along with two poll watchers (Pimentel, 2007). These documented cases confirm that the film's depiction of Emmy's ordeal draws directly from a recurring pattern in Philippine electoral history, rather than an exaggerated or invented threat.

Director Kip Oebanda applies the conventions of the survival thriller, a genre typically centered on an individual attempting to escape danger, to this specific social context. Rather than portraying the teacher as a passive victim of institutional failure, Emmy is presented as someone who actively resists both the threat to her life and the threat to the integrity of the election she is protecting. This approach allows the film to critique how systemic corruption places ordinary public servants in life threatening situations simply for performing their assigned civic duties.

IV. Interpretation

Central Claim: *Balota* argues that within a system defined by corruption and abuse of power, the act of protecting an honest election becomes a form of resistance, and Emmy's willingness to endure suffering for the sake of that honesty is precisely what makes her a threat to those in power.

Evidence 1: Throughout the struggle in the forest, the ballot box remains handcuffed to Emmy's wrist, making it physically impossible for her to set it down or separate herself from it even while being struck, choked, or moving through the unstable, handheld shots of the fight.

How it supports the claim: This detail shifts the meaning of her connection to the box from a choice into a condition she cannot escape. She is not simply choosing not to let go, she is not able to let go, and the film uses this literal restraint to argue that her civic duty has been made inseparable from her body by the very system that assigned it to her in the first place. This mirrors the real situation of Filipino teachers assigned as election inspectors, a danger made concrete by documented cases such as that of Filomena Tatlonghari, who was killed in 1995 while holding onto a ballot box in nearly identical circumstances. Where Tatlonghari chose to hold on, Emmy is bound to hold on, and this distinction sharpens the film's argument: the system does not simply ask ordinary people to risk their lives for an honest election, it physically locks them into that risk, removing any possibility of retreat once the danger begins.

Evidence 2: During the phone call, Emmy withholds her true location from the police despite the pressure placed upon her, while her son is used solely as a means of obtaining that information, since the police show no genuine concern for his well-being beyond this purpose.

How it supports the claim: This exchange demonstrates that cruelty within the system does not require open aggression to be effective. The calm demeanor of the police while committing a serious act of violence suggests that such actions have become routine within this environment, carried out as a task rather than as an exceptional act. This calmness is significant because it reflects how institutional power in the film does not need to announce itself as villainous to be dangerous. It simply follows through on its threats in the same tone it would use for any other order. Emmy's refusal to comply, even as her son is directly threatened, represents a clear act of resistance against a system that

depends on quiet submission rather than visible rebellion. Where the ballot box scene shows her defending an object at the cost of her body, this scene shows her defending a location at the cost of her son, revealing that the same principle governs both choices: she will not surrender what the election requires her to protect, regardless of what is taken from her in return.

Evidence 3: The visual and structural progression of the sequence moves from a soft, unfocused shot, to a near point-of-view perspective, to a calm wide shot, then to an unstable close shot during the fight, and finally into the next scene through a rapid, unsteady pan that carries directly into the following scene without pause.

How it supports the claim: This progression reflects a movement from false security into danger, without offering the audience a moment of visual rest or resolution before the story moves forward. The camera's refusal to settle, even as the story shifts to an entirely new setting, reinforces the idea that Emmy's survival does not translate into safety, and that the disorder introduced by the confrontation carries forward into what happens next, foreshadowing that the danger to her family has not passed.

Evidence 4: The film reinforces this same idea through its use of editing and sound rather than through cinematography alone. The parallel editing between Emmy and the car allows the audience to understand the danger facing her son before she does, while the decision to withhold a direct cut to the shooting keeps the moment of violence entirely off screen. At the same time, the gunshot is placed in the sound mix without any warning or musical buildup, arriving as suddenly as the violence it represents.

How it supports the claim: These choices work together to suggest that violence within this system is administered efficiently and without spectacle, treated by those in power as a routine task rather than a dramatic act. By withholding the visual moment of the shooting and relying instead on sound and Emmy's reaction, the film forces the audience to experience the loss the same way Emmy does, through absence rather than confirmation. This restraint strengthens the central claim, since it shows that the greatest cost of resisting the system is not depicted as a dramatic sacrifice but as a quiet, almost bureaucratic loss, which makes the corruption being criticized feel even more deeply embedded and difficult to confront.

V. Judgment

Balota succeeds in presenting a public servant not as a helpless figure within a failing system, but as someone whose ordinary civic duty becomes an act of significant resistance. This success is largely due to the film's coordinated use of cinematography, editing, and sound, each of which shapes the audience's emotional response rather than simply documenting events. The shift from a calm wide shot to an unstable close shot at the beginning of the fight is not merely a stylistic decision. It reflects the film's broader argument that within a corrupt system, order and violence can exchange places without warning, and because the earlier point of view has already established a sense of unease, the resulting tension feels justified rather than abrupt.

The recurring presence of the ballot box throughout the fight stands as one of the film's most effective choices, communicated entirely through visual composition rather than dialogue. The handcuff binding it to Emmy's wrist transforms what could have been

a simple symbol of dedication into a literal depiction of entrapment, conveying that her civic duty and her physical safety are not something she balances by choice but a single condition she has no way of separating herself from. This method makes the argument more forceful than dialogue alone could achieve, since the audience sees, rather than hears, that she has no way out.

The phone call sequence represents the film at its most disciplined, particularly in its use of sound. The fear it generates is quiet rather than dramatic, and the policeman's calm instruction for Enzo to say his goodbyes proves more unsettling than any raised voice would be, especially given how abruptly the gunshot occurs within the sound mix. The decision to keep the camera on Emmy's face rather than showing her son directly is appropriate, as it requires the audience to experience the violence entirely through her reaction, intensifying the emotional weight of the scene.

The primary weakness of the sequence lies in its occasional reliance on dialogue to convey meaning that the visual and technical elements do not fully express on their own. The smirk of the second policeman, for example, is intended to demonstrate the system's indifference, but this choice is more direct compared to the subtler techniques used elsewhere in the sequence, such as the framing of Enzo inside the car or the unadorned sound design during the shooting. This limitation, however, does not significantly diminish the overall effectiveness of the sequence. *Balota* performs best when it allows its cinematography, editing, and sound design to communicate its argument rather than relying on spoken dialogue, and for most of this sequence, that is precisely what occurs. As a result, the film succeeds in making the cost of upholding an honest election feel immediate, personal, and difficult to overlook.

References

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